

Marry Me Chicken & Spinach Penne Skillet Is the Only High-Protein Dinner You Need

This easy “marry-me” dinner combines tender chicken, sun-dried tomatoes and whole-wheat pasta in a creamy, Parmesan-infused sauce. Fresh spinach and basil brighten the rich flavors, making this comforting meal weeknight-friendly yet special enough for company.

By **Isabelle Easter** | Published on April 3, 2026

✓ Reviewed by Dietitian **Emily Lachtrupp, M.S., RD**

Active Time: 35 mins

Total Time: 35 mins

Servings: 4

Nutrition Profile:

No Added Sugar Mediterranean Diet Sesame-Free Weight Loss Diabetes-Friendly Nut-Free Healthy Pregnancy Healthy Aging Healthy Immunity Soy-Free High-Protein Egg-Free Low-Calorie

Ingredients

8 ounces whole-wheat penne pasta

2 tablespoons oil from sun-dried tomatoes jar

1 pound boneless, skinless chicken breasts or thighs, trimmed and cut into bite-size pieces

½ teaspoon salt, divided

½ teaspoon ground pepper, divided, plus more for garnish

2 medium shallots, chopped

½ cup chopped sun-dried tomatoes

3 medium cloves garlic, minced

1 teaspoon salt-free Italian seasoning

¼ teaspoon crushed red pepper

½ cup lower-sodium chicken broth

1 (5-ounce) package baby spinach

½ cup half-and-half

½ cup grated Parmesan cheese, divided

2 tablespoons loosely packed small fresh basil leaves

Directions

Step 1

Bring a large pot of water to a boil. Add 8 ounces penne; cook according to package directions. Drain and set aside.

Step 2

Meanwhile, heat 2 tablespoons sun-dried tomato oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Add chicken pieces and sprinkle with $\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon each salt and pepper. Cook, stirring occasionally, until an instant-read thermometer inserted into the thickest pieces registers 165°F, 6 to 8 minutes. Transfer to a plate and tent with foil. Do not wipe the skillet clean.

Step 3

Reduce heat to medium and add chopped shallots; cook, stirring often, until softened, about 2 minutes. Add $\frac{1}{2}$ cup sun-dried tomatoes, the minced garlic, 1 teaspoon Italian seasoning, $\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon crushed red pepper and the remaining $\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon each salt and pepper; cook, stirring constantly, until fragrant, about 1 minute. Stir in $\frac{1}{2}$ cup broth, scraping up any browned bits. Bring to a gentle simmer and cook until slightly reduced, about 2 minutes. Add 1 (5-ounce) package spinach in batches; cook until wilted, about 2 minutes.

Step 4

Stir in $\frac{1}{2}$ cup half-and-half and $\frac{1}{3}$ cup Parmesan; bring to a gentle simmer, stirring constantly. Add the cooked pasta and the cooked chicken along with any accumulated juices. Cook, stirring constantly, until the pasta is evenly coated in sauce, about 2 minutes. Remove from heat.

Step 5

Sprinkle with 2 tablespoons basil and the remaining about 3 tablespoons Parmesan. Garnish with additional pepper, if desired.

Frequently Asked Questions

Why is it called “marry me”?



Any “marry me” recipe, like this chicken dish, is so rich and flavorful that it’s said the person who cooks it might receive a marriage proposal.

Can I cook the chicken in advance?



You can cook the chicken in advance, but we don’t recommend it. Doing so may result in losing the flavorful drippings that should be incorporated into the sauce.

What’s the best way to store and reheat leftovers?



Store leftovers in an airtight container in the refrigerator for 3 to 4 days. To reheat, use the stovetop or microwave, adding a splash of broth if needed to loosen the sauce. Heat until warmed through.

Can I freeze it?

We don't recommend freezing this dish because the cream sauce can separate after being frozen, which can make it unappetizing.

What should I serve with Marry Me Chicken & Spinach Penne Skillet?

You'll want a good bread to soak up any leftover sauce; garlic bread would be an excellent choice. A fresh green salad would also complement it well, such as our Leafy Green Salad, Simple Green Salad with Citronette or Massaged Kale Salad. Alternatively, you could pair it with one of our easy veggie sheet-pan recipes, like Garlic-Butter Sheet-Pan Veggies, Lemon-Roasted Mixed Vegetables or Sheet-Pan Roasted Root Vegetables.

Nutrition Facts

Per serving: **Serving Size about 1½ cups** 495 calories; total fat 19g; saturated fat 6g; cholesterol 104mg; sodium 822mg; total carbohydrate 43g; dietary fiber 6g; total sugars 6g; added sugars 0g; protein 41g; vitamin c 16mg; calcium 302mg; iron 4mg; potassium 1085mg

Additional reporting by Sarah Pflugrad, Ph.D., RDN, CSCS and Linda Frahm

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